No Take-Backs

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/26038528.

Rating:
General Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Arranged Marriage, Royalty AU, Tumblr Prompt

Language:
English

Series:
Part 2 of Fic Filled June (for 2k)

Stats:
Published: 2020-08-22 Words: 2,743 Chapters: 1/1

No Take-Backs

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/26038528.

Rating:
General Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Arranged Marriage, Royalty AU, Tumblr Prompt

Language:
English

Series:
Part 2 of Fic Filled June (for 2k)

Stats:
Published: 2020-08-22 Words: 2,743 Chapters: 1/1

No Take-Backs

by sunscreams

Summary

> Catra frowned a little, her eyebrows furrowing together just a little. “What do you mean?” She asked.
>
> “I mean...We’re going to be married," Adora said wth a little shrug, a nervous ball in her throat. "We might as well try to at least be friends; to support each other forever, right?”
>
> “Support each other forever?” Catra asked, her hard look melting just a little.
>
> “Yeah,” Adora said holding her hand out, palm up. “If we’re going to do this, we should at least do it together.”
>
> Catra stared at Adora’s hand for a few long beats before she laid hers on top. “Alright. We will support each other forever. No take-backs.”
>
> Adora beamed. “No take-backs.”

Or the arranged marriage au that lives rent free in my brain.

Notes

The original parts of this fic can be found on Tumblr here, here, and here. If I'm honest, though, this one didn't change much.

All of the June Fics can be found here.

See the end of the work for more notes

Adora had been betrothed to Princess Catrina since before she was born. It was the final line of the mile-long treaty that ended the last war between their countries. It would insure peace for at least the next three generations. The betrothal was Adora's destiny and her duty and she would be a faithful wife and queen someday.

That's what she had been told her whole life.

Even becoming She-Ra, protector of Etheria and the Known Galaxy, had not broken the engagement.

Adora, sometimes selfishly wished she could break off the engagement. She longed to be free from the ties of political engagement. To meet and fall in love with her Fated One like in all of the books she had read as a girl.

But that wasn't her destiny. That wasn't her fate. That wasn't her duty.

Adora would meet her betrothed today, and marry her by the end of the moon cycle, then only nine months after that, Adora would be crowned Queen of Etheria and Empress Consort of Catlantis. It felt like a lot of pressure. Somehow, it felt like more pressure than being She-Ra ever did.

"It'll be alright. I've heard Princess Catrina is very spirited," Queen Mara, the soon to be Queen Mother and former She-Ra, said as she placed a hand on Adora's shoulder. Adora smiled up at her adopted mother and patted the hand on her shoulder.

"Yeah, it'll be fine," she agreed, a little breathless with nerves. "It's just marriage anyway. Way scarier things have happened to me as She-Ra."

Queen Mara laughed lightly and moved her hand to rub Adora's back affectionately. Adora, holding onto the last vestiges of her childhood, leaned into the touch. Queen Mara placed a soft kiss to

Adora's hair before straightening again just as a guard pushed the hall doors open.

"Your Majesty, Your Highness, the Catlantis delegation has arrived," they reported after a short bow.

"Bring them in," Queen Mara said, immediately slipping back into her regal queen persona. Adora did not have a regal queen persona. She was just...Adora. And she wasn't sure if that was going to be enough.

Barely a moment later, the hall doors were pushed open and the delegation from Catlantis strided in. They stood tall and proud, with their chins held high and their armour glinting in the mid-morning sun.

"Welcome Empress Shadow Weaver, Princess Catrina. We hope you travelled well," Queen Mara said, her voice filling the hall as she bowed her head politely to both royals.

"Travelling bores me, Queen Mara, you know this," Empress Shadow Weaver drawled, not returning the polite bow. Adora narrowed her eyes a little at their rudeness. She was marrying into this family?

"Ah, yes, travelling is exhausting," Queen Mara agreed, with a good-natured smile. "Your rooms have been prepared. Hopefully you will not be too tired to join us for the feast we have prepared in you and your daughter's honour."

Empress Shadow Weaver made a dismissive gesture with her hand. "We will see," she said shortly before leaving without dismissal. Adora would have gaped if she was a lesser princess.

She did notice, however, Princess Catrina gave Queen Mara a nod before following her mother out of the hall.

And just like that, the Catlantis delegation was gone. They had barely been in the hall for five minutes. Adora was a little in shock.

“Mother, I am really meant to marry into *that* ?” She asked, a little disbelieving as the doors closed with a thunk behind the delegation.

Queen Mara sighed and rubbed her temples. “Not all of them are like this. It seems Empress Shadow Weaver has just become more insufferable these last few years.” She turned to face Adora fully, her hands coming up to hold Adora’s upper arms. “Don’t worry, darling. I am sure princess Catrina is nothing like her mother.”

Adora glanced back to the main hall doors with worry. She wasn’t so sure she agreed with her mother.

After that somewhat disastrous first meeting, Adora decided she needed some fresh air and made her way out into the garden. What she hadn’t expected to see was Princess Catrina lounging on Adora’s favourite bench nestled comfortably underneath an old oak tree.

Hearing her mother’s voice in her head, Adora made her way over. Perhaps Princess Catrina really wouldn’t be like her mother.

“Princess Catrina,” Adora greeted politely as she approached, “Would you mind if I joined you?”

Princess Catrina’s two-toned eyes snapped up to Adora with a glare. Adora for a moment cursed herself. This was a bad idea after all. Then Princess Catrina sighed and nodded. “As long as you stop calling me Princess Catrina.”

Adora had to fight the smile that threatened to take over her features.

“What should I call you then?” She asked, smoothing her dress down before she sat beside the other princess.

“Catra is fine,” she said, one of her ears twitching as she looked away.

Adora giggled a little. “Catra? Isn’t that a little too...you know?” She asked, nodding towards Catra who was definitely an adorable cat species.

Catra rolled her eyes. “Yeah, thanks for pointing that one out for me, Princess. It’s not like literally everyone and their grandma hasn’t told me that.”

Catra’s voice was abrasive, but Adora just had the urge to giggle. “Right, sorry,” she said, not feeling sorry at all.

They sat in silence for a few beats. The silence was surprisingly comfortable and suddenly Adora felt much better about this marriage. She glanced over at a pouting Catra and had to bite her cheek against another giggle. The other princess really was so adorable.

Adora turned to her a little on the bench, their knees pressing together just a little. “Look, I know you didn’t ask for this,” she started a little seriously which caused Catra to look over in her direction. “I didn’t either. But we both have a duty to our people. So let’s do our best to make the most out of this,” Adora said earnestly.

Catra frowned a little, her eyebrows furrowing together just a little. “What do you mean?” She asked.

“I mean...We’re going to be married," Adora said wth a little shrug, a nervous ball in her throat. "We might as well try to at least be friends; to support each other forever, right?”

“Support each other forever?” Catra asked, her hard look melting just a little.

“Yeah,” Adora said holding her hand out, palm up. “If we’re going to do this, we should at least do it together.”

Catra stared at Adora's hand for a few long beats before she laid hers on top. "Alright. We will support each other forever. No take-backs."

Adora beamed. "No take-backs."

Adora met Catra on their bench, as she always did when they had their monthly meetings since they'd first met 5 months ago. Their wedding was slated for the end of fall which was only 4 more short months away.

As Adora approached what she was beginning to fondly think of as their bench, she noticed the slight slump of Catra's shoulders, and the slight downward bend of her head.

Adora sat down next to her betrothed and offered her hand out. "What's wrong?" She asked softly, the moment calling for a soft voice.

Catra took Adora's hand and leaned her head onto Adora's shoulder. "Mother's—Shadow Weaver's—experiments have been leaked," Catra admitted. They'd briefly talked about Catra's childhood and the experiments her mother had done on her and the other children around her. Catra never went in depth into what happened, or what exactly she had been through, but Adora knew from the way Catra barely held herself together when they spoke about it, and even now, that it hadn't been good.

Adora squeezed Catra's hand tighter to ground her. "What will happen?" Adora asked softly.

"I don't know," Catra breathed, her voice shaking a little around the words. "The people are angry," she added a second later. "The eunuchs speak of rebellion. And I don't know how to quell it. I don't even know if I should."

Adora wrapped her other hand tightly around where both of their hands were clasped. “Forgetting all consequences, what does your heart tell you to do?” Adora asked.

“Run away,” Catra admitted without missing a beat. “I want to take you and run away together.”

Adora tightened her grip and smiled wistfully. “I think I would rather like that as well,” she said. “Perhaps we could build a cabin in the Whispering Woods and live out our lives anonymously.”

Catra let out a soft breath that could have been a laugh if the air wasn’t so full of tension. “You would leave behind She-Ra?”

“Who’s She-Ra?” Adora asked jokingly. In their fantasy, Adora wasn’t She-Ra and neither of them had responsibilities. This actually got a soft laugh out of Catra.

Adora turned her head slightly to press a soft kiss to the top of Catra’s head. “Do what you believe is right, Catra,” Adora said after a few beats.

“I don’t know what is right,” Catra admitted quietly.

Adora took one of her hands and placed it against Catra’s chest. “You do know what is right. It’s in here.” Adora smoothed her thumb against the skin gently. “You can’t give more than yourself,” Adora reminded softly. “But I think you’ll be surprised to see how much that actually is.”

Shortly after their last date, Etheria stopped receiving any and all reports out of Catlantis. So, it was no surprise when Catra missed their next monthly meeting. But...just because it was expected did not mean it wasn’t worrying.

By the end of that month, Adora had managed to get informants back into Catlantis. Adora worried endlessly for Catra as another monthly date came and went. She couldn't stop herself from imagining what might be happening in the neighbouring country. What might be happening to Catra.

When Adora's informants finally got back to her, what they reported about the state of Catlantis was even worse than anything Adora could have imagined.

As She-Ra, Adora has seen rebellions before. She had seen what angry people were capable of. She herself had even helped. And yet, as she read the reports sent to her from Catlantis….she felt a wave of fear and helplessness overwhelm her.

The advisors that supported both Mara and Adora advised them to allow Catlantis to sort out its own disasters. They told Mara to abandon the treaty between their countries and try again with the new government that would rise after the rebellion.

They told Adora to abandon Catra and their marriage.

In that moment, Adora felt nothing but rage. How could they even suggest she abandon Catra? Had they not seen how much they cared for each other? Could they not see what a match they were losing by saying this?

Adora wanted nothing more than to take her sword and storm into Catlantis. She wanted to take Catra and run away. She wanted to abandon this place and these people and really live in a cottage in the woods.

Not once did any of the advisors suggest they go in to mediate.

Not once did any of the advisors suggest they try and help the people.

Not once did anyone suggest not just allowing Catlantis to fall.

And as Adora tried to come up with a way to help, her wedding day came and went.

Adora became Queen of Etheria as if it wasn't also supposed to be her wedding day. She cursed her status, she cursed her duty and she cursed this life.

Adora wished more than anything she could go after Catra.

It was barely a month after Adora's coronation when someone broke into her chambers. It was the dead of night and Adora's guards were right out her door. She could call out for them, have them in her chamber within a second.

But as Adora stared at the empty space in the bed beside her where Catra would have laid if this was their honeymoon, Adora found she couldn't move, let alone speak. Perhaps if she was killed tonight it would forgive the fact that she allowed her betrothed to die.

Adora felt the person stop at the edge of the bed, right at her back and waited for the knife to plunge into her body. She waited for the pain—excruciating and hot—before nothing. She...she longed for it.

But it never came.

"Adora?" The figure's voice was soft and a little hoarse from behind Adora—and—and Adora knew that voice. But it was—

Adora turned over and sat up—

But it was too dark and Adora couldn't—

She reached for the oil lamp on her table and fumbled—

She needed to see—

There was no way it could be—

She got the light on and there—

There was Catra.

Her hair was shorter, cut off at odd angles as if done in a rush. She had a scar on her jaw and she looked smaller without the ceremonial dress she usually wore.

She was...she was a sight for sore eyes.

“Catra?” Adora managed, unable to believe it was really her. Unable to allow herself to hope.

She reached up to cup Catra’s cheek. She needed to touch to make sure she was real. Catra let her eyes slip closed and she leaned into the touch. Her skin was so soft, and Adora wanted nothing more than to pull her into a deep kiss.

Catra smiled softly, her shoulders relaxing as if a weight had been lifted off of her shoulders. She let out a breathy laugh and said, “Hey Adora.” It was music to Adora’s ears.

Suddenly touching Catra’s cheek wasn’t enough anymore. Adora shot forward and wrapped her arms around Catra. “You’re alive,” Adora breathed happily.

Catra hugged her back just as tightly, her face fitting perfectly into Adora’s neck. “Yeah. I’m alive. Just barely though.”

“I’m so glad,” Adora breathed then let out a little shaky breath. “What happened? Why are you here?” Adora asked after a beat, finally pulling away to look at Catra.

“Long story,” Catra sighed, rolling her eyes. “Nothing too bad. Just on a mission to win back my people. You know how it goes,” Catra shrugged, still funny after everything. Adora laughed helplessly.

“Is there any way She-Ra could help?” Adora asked, desperately wanting to help.

“No, this is something I need to do on my own,” Catra said, sounding thankful for the offer. She stepped closer, her thighs bumping into Adora’s knees. Catra looked down and took both of Adora’s hands in her own. “I came because...It’s selfish, but I wanted to see you one last time.”

Adora squeezed Catra’s hands. “I’m glad you came,” she admitted. “I’ve missed you. I’ve...I’ve been so worried.”

Catra squeezed Adora’s hands back and then ran her thumb across Adora’s knuckles. Adora’s belly swooped at the gesture. “I’m sorry,” she said softly. Then a second later she added, “I wish I could stay.”

“It’s okay,” Adora said automatically, “I wish you could stay as well, but…” she smiled a little up at Catra, “You have to do what you believe is right for your people.”

Catra nodded and let out a sigh of relief, as if she was expecting Adora not to understand. Adora squeezed her hands again and wanted to pull her down into the bed with her, but knew Catra surely had to leave soon.

“I need to ask you something,” Catra said after a beat. “You can say no, but...I have to ask.” Catra looked back up at Adora, her mis-matched eyes shining in the moonlight.

“Okay,” Adora nodded a little.

Catra looked back at their hands and collected herself. When she looked up again, Catra’s eyes were pools of desperation and sadness. “Can you wait for me?” She whispered out, as if she spoke any louder, the words themselves would swallow her whole.

Adora straightened and held Catra’s hands in a crushing grip. “Of course,” she said firmly. “Catra, of course I will wait for you.”

Adora felt something like relief as Catra let out a breathy laugh. Her stomach swooped as Catra leaned in and stole her lips in a deep kiss. Catra's hand was soft on Adora's cheek.

Adora would wait a hundred years and longer for Catra. Whatever it took, Adora would wait.

End Notes

Catradora Tumblr
Personal Tumblr
Twitter

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!